new Cuban task force. Khrushchev recalled the circumstances of Pliev's appointment years later: "Malinovsky, as minister of defense, proposed that General of the Army Pliev, an Ossetian by nationality, be confirmed as leader. General Pliev was summoned, and I spoke with him. He was already of advanced age and ill but knew his business. He had served throughout the Patriotic War, and I believe that he had also taken part in the Civil War. I more or less knew him as commander of a cavalry corps in the Second World War. An intelligent man. Pliev said that if he were confirmed, he would consider it a personal honor to go to Cuba and carry out the task assigned to him." Khrushchev had found in Pliev the kind of experience and loyalty he was looking for. He saw nothing wrong with a cavalry man from the past war taking charge of the nuclear weapons that could start a future one.[14]

Pliev headed a group of missile-force generals and officers who had been personally approved by Khrushchev before Pliev took command of the task force. The favorite of the missile lobby, General Dankevich, was appointed Pliev's first deputy. Dankevich's deputy in the Vinnytsia missile division, General Leonid Garbuz, became Pliev's deputy in charge of battle readiness of troops, while General Aleksei Dementiev, who had told Khrushchev that it would be difficult to hide even a chicken on Cuban terrain, was approved as Pliev's deputy in charge of ground troops. A calm, soft-spoken man with a smile on his lips under a small black mustache, Pliev was good at dealing with people but was ill prepared for the operation he was about to lead.

Having spent most of his military career in the cavalry, he knew little about missiles and, to the ridicule of his subordinates, used the term "squadron," reserved in the Soviet Army exclusively for a cavalry unit, to refer to missile detachments. He also had no diplomatic experience—a liability in his new position, which demanded a good deal of it. On top of that he was ill, suffering from a kidney disease, and the General Staff had to ship a personal doctor to attend to the general with the next reconnaissance group, which left for Cuba on July 18. Old, sickly, and incompetent, Pliev was now surrounded by young and ambitious deputies who had little respect for their commander. Khrushchev and Malinovsky got what they wanted—a man they considered loyal and smart was now in charge of the